

ANDHRA PRADESH'S DEMOGRAPHIC TURNING POINT

Building a Future-Ready Society

Andhra Pradesh today stands at a decisive demographic moment. For decades, the state, like much of India, focused on controlling population growth. But the demographic reality has changed dramatically. Andhra Pradesh now faces a different challenge: declining fertility, a shrinking youth population and a rapidly ageing society. Recognising this transformation, the state government has begun crafting a comprehensive population management framework designed not to control population numbers, but to harness demographic change for long term economic and social progress.

The numbers underline the urgency of this shift. Andhra Pradesh's Total Fertility Rate (TFR) is estimated at around **1.5**, well below the replacement level of **2.1**, placing it among India's lowest fertility regions alongside southern states such as Tamil Nadu and Kerala. At the same time, the **median age in the state has risen to 32.5 years**, significantly higher than the national average of 28.4 years, indicating a steadily ageing population.

While these trends are often associated with advanced economies such as Japan or South Korea, Andhra Pradesh is experiencing them while still navigating the challenges of a developing economy. For policymakers, the implications are profound. A declining birth rate means fewer young workers entering the labour force in the coming decades, while the proportion of elderly citizens is projected to rise sharply.

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This shift will place greater pressure on healthcare systems, pension schemes and social security programmes, while simultaneously reducing the size of the productive workforce that supports economic growth.

Yet, the Andhra Pradesh government sees this challenge as an opportunity. Rather than viewing population trends as a crisis, the state has begun framing them as a strategic development issue. The emerging policy framework adopts what officials describe as a **"life cycle model" of population management**, focusing on improving health, education, gender equality and skills across all stages of life.